

Geography Exam Structured Questions Notes

<https://gemini.google.com/app/da6874fa54b1f5d7>

User prompt: summarize into study notes for https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qaUNXBPPZUg&list=PLA_pcHk-I3EQn-VH2SaAG7ILOPTVpLgTR&index=19
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Sv3l2GBLz1I&list=PLA_pcHk-I3EQn-VH2SaAG7ILOPTVpLgTR&index=18

Response: Here are structured study notes based on the tutorial videos by **Bernice Loon** on answering "**Explain**" and "**Describe**" structured questions in Geography examinations.

Part 1: How to Answer "EXPLANATION" Structured Questions

1. Recognizing Explanation Command Words

Explanation questions require you to **tap into content knowledge to provide reasons**. Watch out for these variations:

- **Explain / Account for**
- **Give reasons for / Suggest reasons for**
- **Suggest how / Justify**

2. Common Student Mistakes

- **Overwriting / Information Dump:** Memorizing textbook content and regurgitating everything without paying attention to the mark allocation.
- **Failing to Link to Question Demands:** Writing correct geographical facts without explicitly connecting them back to the specific context requested (e.g., writing about fertile soil without explaining the *economic* benefit to the people).

3. Mark Allocation & Point Planning Strategy

Standard scoring guidelines for explanation questions:

- **1 Mark** = Brief explanation point
- **2 Marks** = Detailed explanation point (cause-and-effect chain)
- **1 Mark** = Valid, relevant example

Point Permutations for a 5-Mark Question:

1. **5 Brief Points:** 5 points $\times$ 1 mark = 5 marks
2. **3 Detailed Points:** 3 points $\times$ 2 marks = 6 marks (*gives full 5 marks*)

3. **2 Detailed Points + 1 Example:** (2 points × 2 marks) + 1 mark = 5 marks

Exception (Process Questions): For questions explaining physical processes (e.g., *formation of southwest monsoon winds*), mark schemes usually award **1 mark per step/process linked sequentially** rather than 2 marks per detailed point.

4. 4-Step Checklist for Unpacking Explanation Questions

1. **Observe Command Words:** Check if it asks for a single command or a dual command (e.g., "*Describe and account for...*" requires both description and reasoning).
2. **Check Resource References:** If asked "*With reference to Figure 1...*", you **must** incorporate specific data, country names, or visual evidence from the figure into your answer to earn full credit.
3. **Identify Question Demands:** Look for qualifiers (e.g., *economic* benefits vs. *social* benefits) and ensure every point explicitly links back to them.
4. **Plan Points via Mark Allocation:** Use simple math before writing to manage your time and avoid overwriting.

Part 2: How to Answer "DESCRIBE" Structured Questions

1. Core Golden Rules for Description Questions

- **NO Explanation or Justification:** Only state **what you see**. Do not explain *how* or *why* a landform/trend formed unless explicitly asked (e.g., "*Describe and explain...*").
- **Strict Mark Adherence:** If a question is worth 3 marks, write 3 concise descriptive points. Do not write half a page of memorized notes.

2. Answering Strategies by Data/Resource Type

A. World Maps / Spatial Distributions

- **General Trend:** State the overall distribution using latitude lines or major reference points (e.g., "*Concentrated within the tropics between 23.5°N and 23.5°S*").
- **Highest Concentration:** Identify areas with the highest density of features (e.g., "*Concentrated in the Caribbean Sea*").
- **Clustered / Scattered Patterns:** Note regions where data points are scattered across bodies of water or specific regions.
- **Specific Examples & Prior Knowledge:** Name specific continents, oceans, or countries if they are not explicitly labeled on the map (e.g., "*Off the coast of Sri Lanka, Thailand, and Indonesia*").

B. Topographical Maps & Photographs

- **Topographical Contour Maps:**

- Close contour lines = steep gradient/top; widely spaced contour lines = gentle gradient/base.
- Check for symmetry (e.g., symmetrical volcanic cone).
- Use the **Direction Arrow** (North, East, South, West) to describe feature locations (e.g., *"Rock face exposed on the eastern slope"*).
- Systematically run through the key/legend (craters, lava flows, vegetation, beaches).
- **Photographs:**
 - Recall geographical terminology (e.g., *"Long, linear depression"* for rift valleys; *"Steep sides with a flat top"* for block mountains).
 - Note visible physical details systematically (e.g., horizontal lines of weakness, vegetation coverage, presence of rivers).

C. Graphs (Line, Bar, & Scatter Graphs)

- **Relationships (Line / Scatter Graphs):**
 1. **State the Relationship First:** Identify if it is **positive/direct**, **negative/inverse**, or has **no relationship**.
 2. **Quote Statistics:** Provide highest, lowest, or specific values with correct units (e.g., temperatures in °C, money in Euros).
 3. **Note Anomalies:** Highlight outliers or unexpected data pairs (e.g., two countries with different disposable income levels but identical food spending).
 - **Dual-Command Graphs ("*Describe and Explain*"):**
 - Allocate marks evenly between description (quoting trends + statistics) and content explanation.
 - For bar charts, highlight overall trends across time (e.g., *"Overall increase from 2007 to 2017"*) and quote the extreme changes (highest increase/decrease).
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